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Daily Life in Ancient Egypt

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How the World Turned Upside-Down : An Examination of Egyptian Cartography Before and
After the Battle of Actium

There's one aspect of Ancient Egyptian culture that, I believe, stands out among all others. It differentiates it from modernity, and becomes immediately apparent at only a glance: Upper Egypt, contrary to what one may initially think, is actually south of Lower Egypt. This may strike one as being 'upside-down,' but— to an Ancient Egyptian, this is entirely not so. It is evident through the geographical maps of Ancient Egypt, such as the Turin Papyrus map, that an Ancient Egyptian would have perceived the cardinal directions differently, with 'south' at the top and 'north' at the bottom. In fact, Ancient Egyptian maps of all kinds— from the previously mentioned geographical, to the cosmological, to even maps of the afterlife— can provide valuable insight into Ancient Egyptian culture.

Of course, however, culture is a continuously evolving construct. All of our modern maps are 'right-side up,' with 'north' at the top and 'south' at the bottom (it is important to briefly note here that while this paper uses terms such as 'upside-down' and 'right-side up' for ease of explanation, it is not my intention to portray these maps as wrong or incorrect, as they reflect a different culture and exist in a specific cultural context), unlike the maps of the Ancient Egyptians. In 31 BCE, Rome— whose maps had the orientation of those we use today— officially absorbed Ptolemaic Egypt as one of its provinces following the Battle of Actium. After this conquest, Egyptian maps undoubtedly change, which can be used to show how Ancient

Egyptian culture evolved under Rome's influence, therefore displaying the vast effects that Rome had on its neighboring cultures, creating cultural shifts that have persisted into modernity.

Beginning with geographical maps, we take a look at what has been described as the “oldest known geographic map in the world,” the Turin Papyrus map.¹ While not confirmed, it is plausible that it was drawn by a senior artist at Dier el-Medina, Amenakhte². It exists in fifteen surviving fragments (Fig. 1), which today reside in the Turin Museum in Italy. The fragments themselves appear to depict parts of the Wadi Hammamat, a Wadi route that stretches between the Nile River and the Red Sea used by the Ancient Egyptians to mine various stones and minerals, particularly gold.³ The map depicts the route itself as a single pinkish-brownish line, with tall, black hills on either side; These hills are labeled as the “mountain of bekheny” in the map's annotations.⁴ Pink hills appear as well, referred to as “mountains of gold,” for they are in fact gold-bearing; additionally, various quarries and workers' settlements dot the drawn landscape⁵. The most important feature of this map, however, is its orientation: Amenakhte has drawn what appears to be ‘south’ at the top of his map, and has placed ‘north’ at the bottom.⁶

¹O'Connor and Talbert, “From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps,” 59.

² O'Connor and Talbert, “From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps,” 59.

³ O'Connor and Talbert, “From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps,” 62.

⁴ O'Connor and Talbert, “From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps,” 63.

⁵ O'Connor and Talbert, “From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps,” 64.

⁶ O'Connor and Talbert, “From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps,” 63.

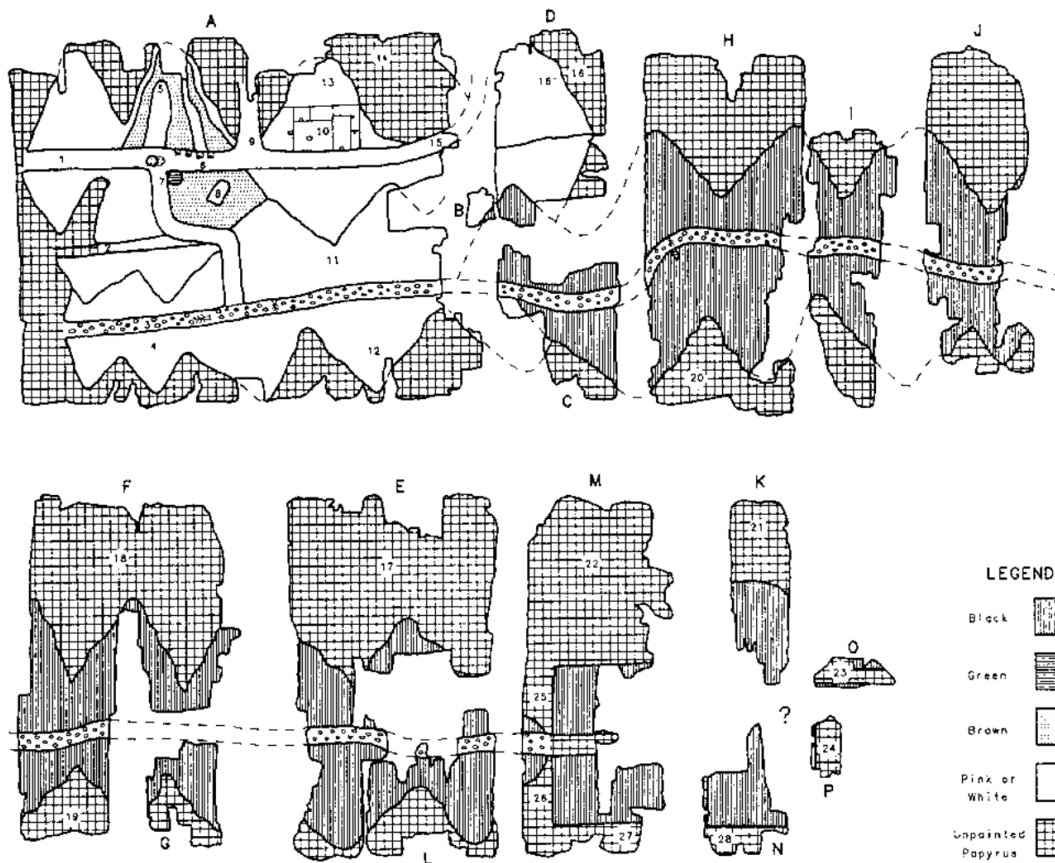


Fig. 1 A rendition of the 15 surviving fragments of the Turin Papyrus. From O'Connor and Talbert, "From Topography to Cosmos: Ancient Egypt's Multiple Maps," 63.

It's not just geographical maps that have this 'south-north' orientation, however. A cosmographical map— cosmographical referring to the order of the world or the universe— carved into the cover of a stone sarcophagus (Fig. 2) from Saqqara dating to the Thirtieth Dynasty, around 350 BCE⁷, depicts the goddess Nut, stretching over the universe as the sky. The inner circular band depicts the different nomes of Ancient Egypt— defined by Shore as

⁷ Shore, "Egyptian Cartography," 120.

“ancient territorial divisions”⁸— while the outer circular band depicts Ancient Egypt’s different neighbors, and the vast array of people who live there. Finally, on the left and right are the Ancient Egyptian goddesses of the east and west, respectively. This east-west orientation seems to imply that, like the Turin Map Papyrus, this sarcophagus map has a south-north orientation, with ‘north’ at the bottom and ‘south’ at the top.



Fig. 2 A cosmographical map of the Ancient Egyptian world carved into the cover of a stone sarcophagus at Saqqara. From Shore, "Egyptian Cartography," 120.

⁸ Shore, "Egyptian Cartography," 121.

The reasoning behind this south-north orientation is directly intertwined with the Nile River and its place in Ancient Egyptian culture. The Nile existed at the heart of Ancient Egyptian life; Its annual flooding turned the areas bordering the Nile— where little could grow— into the most fertile farming regions in the world.⁹ The Faiyum— ‘the Desert Paradise’ or ‘Egypt’s Garden’— was created by the waters of the Nile flooding to lower ground, thus creating the sprawling oasis.¹⁰ This miraculous flooding was considered a great wonder of the gods, or later to the kings as gods themselves;¹¹ The Ancient Egyptians bore witness to the yearly miracle of the river’s flooding and creation of rich, fertile land perfect for agriculture. As such, the Nile was also a key part of Ancient Egyptian religious life; Terje Tvedt explains in his book— *The Nile: History’s Greatest River*— that “religious traditions in ancient Egypt, as in all the major river civilizations in the Middle East and Asia around the same time, arose literally among people who conducted their lives along the banks of the great rivers.”¹² The Nile’s cyclical flood reminded the Ancient Egyptians of other religious symbols, such as the scarab beetle rolling its ball of dung, therefore tying it to the Ancient Egyptian ideas of life and rebirth that those symbols represented.¹³ Tvedt explains that “the beetle, in addition to proving the basis for the first myths,

⁹ Tvedt, *The Nile : History’s Greatest River*, 28

¹⁰ Tvedt, *The Nile : History’s Greatest River*, 27

¹¹ Tvedt, *The Nile : History’s Greatest River*, 29

¹² Tvedt, *The Nile : History’s Greatest River*, 29.

¹³ Tvedt, *The Nile : History’s Greatest River*, 29.

evokes the Nile as a producer of ideas regarding eternal life and as a creator of societal existence.”¹⁴

From agriculture, to religion, to even taxes and mathematics,¹⁵ the Nile River was truly at the center of life in Ancient Egypt. Its most relevant feature when speaking on cartography, however, is the direction in which it flows, which is from south to north. It makes complete sense, then, why Upper Egypt is, from a modern perspective, south of Lower Egypt. To be closer to the source of the Nile River would mean being closer to the very source and center of life for all of Ancient Egypt; To an Ancient Egyptian, it is the source of food, and therefore life, a miracle brought on by the might of the gods. Since Ancient Egyptian life is centered around this river, it would then naturally influence how an Ancient Egyptian would perceive the world geographically. Thus, Upper Egypt becomes the ‘north,’ closer to the source of the Nile, and Lower Egypt becomes the ‘south,’ closer to the delta; The perception of the world becomes ‘flipped,’ which is evident in both the Turin Papyrus map and the cosmological “Sarcophagus” map. This ‘flipped’ map orientation therefore provides valuable insight on the importance of the Nile in Ancient Egyptian culture.

¹⁴ Tvedt, *The Nile : History's Greatest River*, 29.

¹⁵ Tvedt, *The Nile : History's Greatest River*, 29.

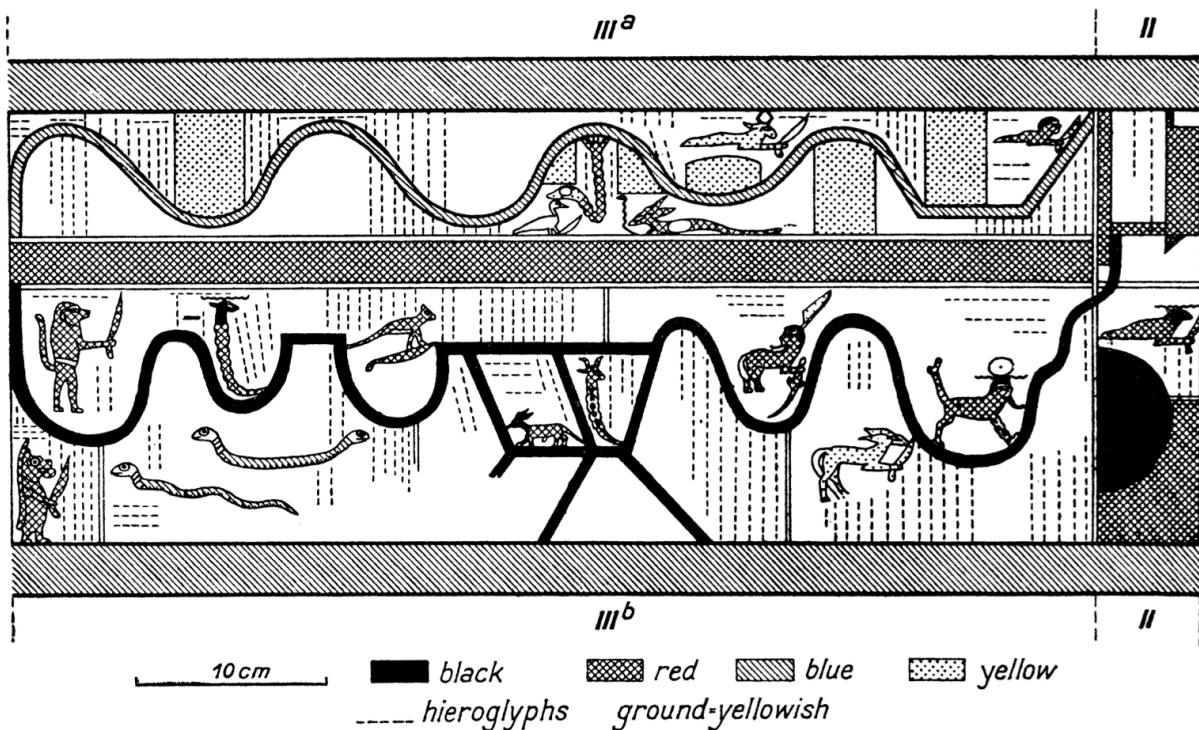


Fig. 4. The map (chapter II and III) of the coffin-bottom No. 28,083.

Fig. 3 The Bottom of Coffin No. 28,083 illustrating the “land way” and the “water way” described in the “Book of the Dead.” From ¹ Bonacker, W. “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 12.

While these cosmological and geographical maps serve to illustrate the land of the living, the Ancient Egyptians also took great care in creating visualized ‘maps’ of the afterlife. “The Book of Two Ways,” for example, is the oldest text in a group of text known as the “Guides to the Beyond,” describing the journey one’s soul may take through the afterlife following their death.¹⁶ Many of them, including the “Book of Two Ways,” are illustrated, and can give us a glimpse of what Ancient Egyptian peoples thought occurred post-mortem.¹⁷ The texts themselves

¹⁶ Bonacker, “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 6.

¹⁷ Bonacker, Wilhelm. “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 6.

are actually engraved directly onto the coffins of the deceased, which were excavated at Dar el-Bersha, a Middle Kingdom necropolis, and are dated to the turn of the 11th Dynasty into the 12th.¹⁸ On the bottom of coffin No. 28,083 (Fig. 3), for example, is drawn a vibrantly colored picture depicting the aforementioned two ways: a “water way,” illustrated with a single winding blue line, labeled as the “way of the living person” and leading towards a dangerous fire ocean (regarding that fire ocean, the map helpfully informs its reader that “you must not go on it”)¹⁹, and a dark-colored “land way,” which is dotted by fearsome watchmen and snakes, and ends abruptly with no clear destination.²⁰ While one might expect these two paths to eventually end at the divine paradise sought by the Ancient Egyptians, both ways end guarded by “two armed watchmen that the deceased had to overwhelm.”²¹ The ‘realm of the dead’ that this text seeks to map out is, like the last two examples, closely tied with the Nile River, as the Ancient Egyptians believed that the land itself was traversed by a subterranean Nile.²² Beyond the actual presence of the river, this nether world also shares similarities with the Nile itself, as it is part of a “life after death” in accordance with Ancient Egyptian religious practices²³ while the river is a symbol of cyclical death and rebirth. It would seem, then, that just like the maps meant for the living, the

¹⁸ Bonacker, Wilhelm. “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 5.

¹⁹ Bonacker, W. “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 11.

²⁰ Bonacker, W. “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 12.

²¹ Bonacker, “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 12.

²² Bonacker, “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 13.

²³ Bonacker, “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 13.

maps meant for the death have a deep, intrinsic tie with the Nile River, further exemplifying just how important it was in Ancient Egyptian culture.

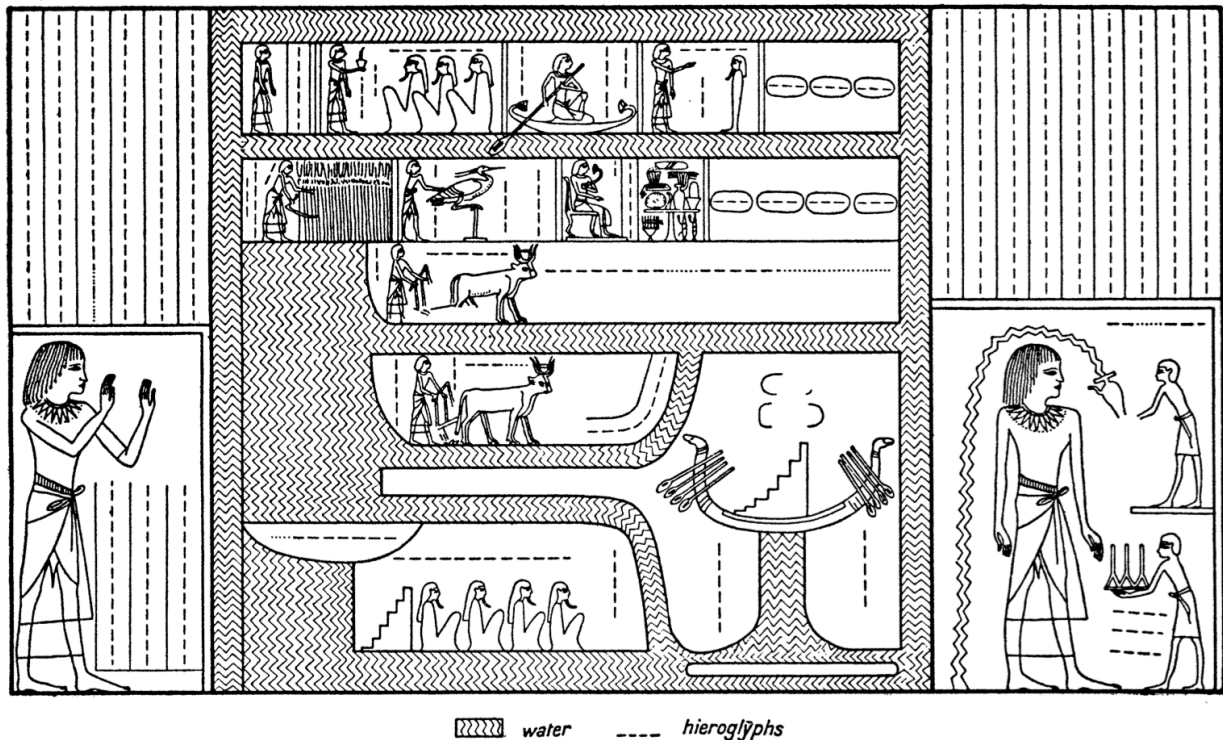


Fig. 4 An illustration of the “Elysian Fields” meant to accompany the saying 110 of the “Book of the Dead. From Bonacker, “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 15.

Another example of these ‘maps’ of the afterlife comes from saying 110 of the “Book of the Dead.” That name is slightly misleading; The “Book of the Dead” is not a singular work of literature, but an extremely expansive collection of various texts, including “spells and incantations, prayers, hymns, litanies and magical formulae... mythological sequences, [and] procedures for treating the deceased.”²⁴ The title of “Book of the Dead” is derived from the name

²⁴ Grof, S. *Books of the dead*, 7.

Kitab al-Mayitun ('book of the dead person'), the generalized name given by tomb robbers to whatever papyrus was found with the mummies; the original Egyptian title, *Pert em hru*, can be translated to mean 'manifestation in the light' or 'chapters of everyday arrival.'²⁵ Saying 110 is just one spell of many used to help guide a soul through the afterlife²⁶; here, it guides the dead to the "Elysian fields," the paradise sought at the end of the two ways. The saying itself reads as follows: "Sayings about the field of dishes; the spells for going out in day-time; entering and leaving the world of the dead, inhabiting in the rush-grounds, staying in the field of dishes, the great town of winds, having power there, being transfigured there, ploughing there, harvesting there, eating there, drinking there, cohabiting there, doing all that one is accustomed to do on earth."²⁷

The accompanying illustration (Fig. 4) depicts just what the spell describes; the "Elysian Fields" — also known as the "rush grounds" or the "field of dishes" as it is referred to in the spell itself— is a landscape dotted with islands upon which the deceased ride on plows pulled by oxen and leisurely cut down rows of grain. This agricultural utopia was the residence of the "blessed deceased"²⁸ whose hearts were found to be lighter than the feather of Ma'at²⁹ and who were able to traverse through the dangers of the nether world. The boats that carry these 'blessed'

²⁵ Grof, S. *Books of the dead*, 7.

²⁶ Stevenson, "Journeys to the Afterlife," 78.

²⁷ Bonacker, "The Egyptian 'Book of the Two Ways,'" 14.

²⁸ Bonacker, "The Egyptian 'Book of the Two Ways,'" 14.

²⁹ Stevenson, "Journeys to the Afterlife," 78.

dead from island to island have snake heads at both the bow and the stern, calling back to the snake imagery present in the ‘land way’ of the “Book of Two Ways” and therefore grounding the illustration in the afterlife and funerary imagery.³⁰ The striking agricultural imagery is just as relevant; it appears to evoke the Nile, with the eternal farmwork occurring in areas bordering the water, reminiscent of the farming that occurred in the fertile floodplain of the Nile. Just as the Nile continues the cycle of life, death and rebirth with its yearly flood, the dead in the “field of dishes” are experiencing their new “life after death.” The “Book of the Dead” therefore serves as a compelling example of how Ancient Egyptian cartography showcases the importance of the Nile River within its culture.

Meanwhile, in Rome, cartographers were similarly hard at work making their own maps. Strabo, for example, lived during the latter half of the first century BCE and the first few decades of the first century CE.³¹ His hometown was Amaseia (modern Amasya), which had been under Roman control from the time of his birth.³² He would live and produce much of his work in the Egyptian city of Alexandria, including his most famous work, his *Geographica*, translated as “Geography”³³; However, he appears to have spent a larger portion of his life living, learning, and traveling between cities in Italy such as Rome, and cities in Ancient Greece such as Nysa—

³⁰ Bonacker, “The Egyptian ‘Book of the Two Ways,’” 15.

³¹ Strabo and Potheary, “Brief Introduction,” xvii.

³² Roller, “Introduction,” 3

³³ Strabo and Potheary “Brief Introduction,” xvii.

both areas being under Roman rule.³⁴ By the time he came to Egypt, it was freshly under Roman control³⁵, and during his time living there he returned to Rome—possibly more than once.³⁶ With Strabo having grown up and educated himself in Roman territories, returning to Rome throughout his life, there is no doubt that his work, *Geographica*—published in 23 or 24 CE,³⁷ too soon after Rome absorbed Egypt to show a long-term cultural shift—would reflect a Roman perception of geography.

The *Geographica* itself, standing at more than a third of one million words,³⁸ contains everything its author knew about the world, including “how to tame elephants and information on the production of asphalt, how saffron is collected, the treatment of old people, the practice of yoga, the lineage of obscure eastern dynasties, religious festivals, prostitution, and volcanic activity.”³⁹ Of course, it also provides geographic descriptions that—while not being part of a drawn out, visual map—display a Roman understanding of cardinal directions similar to our modern understanding; Strabo describes a world in which ‘north’ sits at the top, and ‘south’ sits at the bottom. For example, when describing Italy and the nearby islands, Strabo notes that “nevertheless, in the case of the [?parallelogram, ?clima, ?triangle]

³⁴ Roller, “Introduction,” 6

³⁵ Roller, “Introduction,” 9

³⁶ Roller, “Introduction,” 10

³⁷ Roller, “Introduction,” 16

³⁸ Strabo and Potheary, “Brief Introduction,” xvii.

³⁹ Strabo and Potheary, “Brief Introduction,” xvii.

of Sicily, situated south of Italy, Pelorias would correctly be said to be the ‘northernmost’ of the three corners...”⁴⁰ The region which he describes, a promontory called Capo Peloro,⁴¹ is in fact the northeastern-most point of Sicily, displaying a Roman perception of geography that greatly differs from an Ancient Egyptian one, with ‘north’ at the top of the world, and ‘south’ at the bottom, rather than the other way around.

As previously alluded to, Rome would eventually end up assuming full control of Egypt following the Battle of Actium on September 2nd, 31 BCE⁴², which took place as a naval battle on the Ionian Sea.⁴³ It was the final settlement of a conflict that began with the assassination of Julius Caesar in 44 BCE.⁴⁴ Mark Antony was a loyal follower of Caesar, and Octavian was the late dictator’s newly appointed heir; These two men— despite the fact that they would join together as allies with Marcus Aemilius Lepidus in the second triumvirate to crush Caesar’s assassins— would eventually face each other in the battle that would shape the fate of Egypt forever.⁴⁵ Following their defeat of the conspirators, the three men split up Rome’s territory.

⁴⁰ Strabo, "Translation of Strabo’s Geography part 2," 314.

⁴¹ Strabo, "Translation of Strabo’s Geography part 2," 314.

⁴² Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 2.

⁴³ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 15.

⁴⁴ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 4.

⁴⁵ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 4.

When Octavian dismissed Lepidus and took his share for himself, however, Mark Antony was greatly displeased, thus beginning the long road of rising tensions between them.

This tension would only grow stronger as Mark Antony, while preparing for a military campaign against the Parthians (who resided in Ancient Persia; Modern day Iran, Iraq, and Afghanistan), summoned Cleopatra— queen of then Ptolemaic Egypt— to question her as to why she had provided aid to the men who had conspired against Caesar.⁴⁶ Instead of the conflict one may expect from such a question, however, Mark Antony was enamored with Cleopatra and quickly fell in love with her wit and charms.⁴⁷ The military campaign he had prepared for ended up a complete and utter and utter disaster, with Mark Antony eventually being forced to flee in order to escape death.⁴⁸ Those back in Rome, including Octavian, were convinced that Mark Antony had been softened by his love for Cleopatra and the pleasures of the East,⁴⁹ a region which the Romans considered “a land of debauchery and lust, which weakened the body and the mind.”⁵⁰ Mark Antony even went on to give Roman territories to the children he fathered with Cleopatra while still being married to Octavius’ sister, Octavia, whom he was continuously embarrassing.⁵¹ The final straw for Octavian was when Mark Antony refused to be associated

⁴⁶ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 6.

⁴⁷ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 17.

⁴⁸ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 7.

⁴⁹ Bernardi, and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 7.

⁵⁰ Bernardi, and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 6.

⁵¹ Bernardi, and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 8

with his sister anymore at all; Soon, a conflict became unavoidable.⁵² In 32 BCE, with Octavian having managed to convince the senate that Mark Antony was now an “oriental prince and an enemy of Rome,”⁵³ Rome declared war— notably, not on Mark Antony— but on Cleopatra, whom many viewed as the true cause of the conflict.⁵⁴

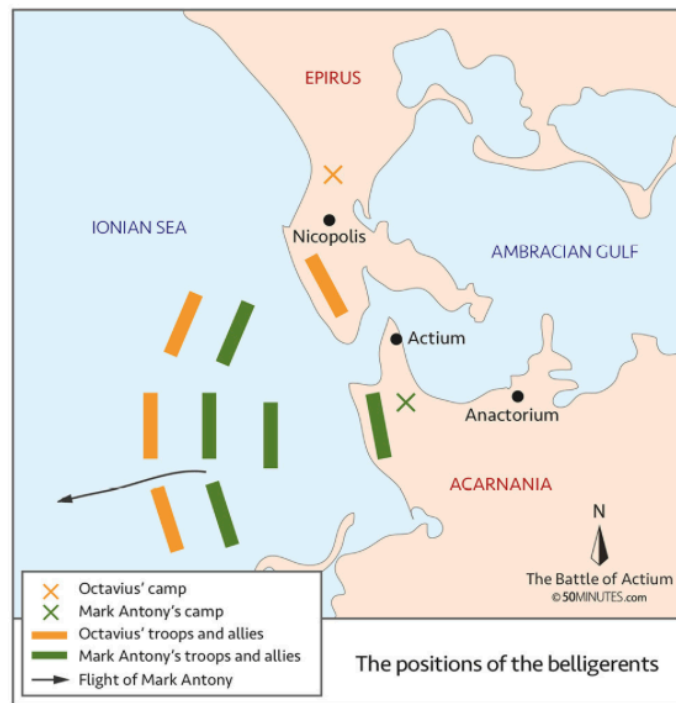


Fig. 6 The position of the forces at the Battle of Actium. From Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 15

The two forces prepared and eventually met face to face— Mark Antony, with 300 towering vessels, 200 smaller, Egyptian ones, and 200,00 men, and Octavian, with 400 small,

⁵² Bernardi, and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 8

⁵³ Bernardi, and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 8

⁵⁴ Bernardi, and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 8

Roman ships and 80,000 men (Fig. 6).⁵⁵ Despite Octavian's smaller forces, his fleet was supplied with professional sailors, while Mark Antony had only cavalry and infantry forces hastily enlisted for the sake of this conflict.⁵⁶ The superior speed of Octavian's ships allowed him to lure Mark Antony's forces further out into the sea, before assaulting them on all sides.⁵⁷ Before the outcome could even be predicted (although the battle would later fall into Octavian's favor), Cleopatra abruptly fled the battle, calling her subjects to follow; Noticing her absence, Mark Antony would follow soon after.⁵⁸ Octavian would eventually overwhelm the remaining forces of Mark Antony— launching attacks of flaming arrows to burn down the enemy ships— and the Romans would soon emerge victorious.⁵⁹ Within a year following, Mark Antony and Cleopatra would both be dead, having both ended their own lives, and Octavian would then officially reduce Egypt to a mere province of Rome, marking the end of the Ptolemaic Dynasty and Egyptian Rule.⁶⁰

⁵⁵ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 13

⁵⁶ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 13

⁵⁷ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 15

⁵⁸ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 17.

⁵⁹ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 17.

⁶⁰ Bernardi and Cartelet, *The Battle of Actium : The End of the Roman Civil Wars*, 18

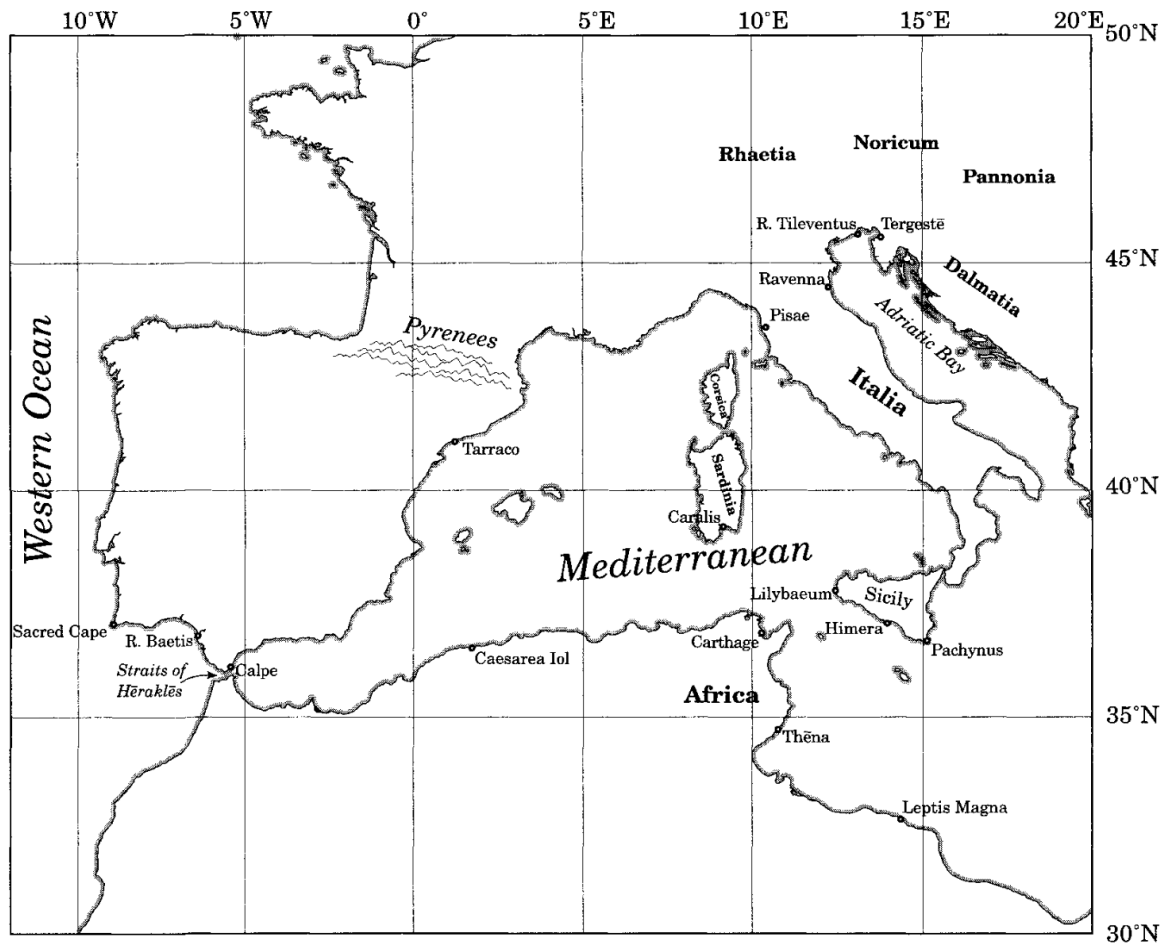


Fig. 5 Map 5B in Ptolemy's *Geography* depicting the Mediterranean and the land surrounding it.

From Berggren and Jones, "Maps 1-8," 94

In the years following, Ancient Egyptian culture would naturally begin to change in accordance with the new ruling party, which can be seen in the maps created after Egypt became a Roman province. Cartography and map making would also see massive improvements; one of history's most famous cartographers is Ptolemy, who was born around 100 CE, living and working in or near Alexandria.⁶¹ Given that Ptolemy appears to have spent much more of his life in

⁶¹ Berggren and Jones, "Introduction," 18

Egypt relative to Strabo, and his work— the *Geographia*, also translated as “Geography” — was published far later, his cartographical work is a much more reliable example of Egypt’s cultural changes under Roman rule. Ptolemy’s *Geography*, as with Strabo’s, describes the cardinal directions in the Roman and modern fashion, rather than the Egyptian. He writes, in reference to drawing a map, “our convention is that ‘up’ with respect to the map-makers' or spectators' view means ‘north,’ and ‘right’ means ‘east’ ... both on a globe and on a planar map.”⁶² Many manuscripts of Ptolemy’s work actually include drawn maps; most manuscripts, for example, include a world map drawn up in accordance with Ptolemy’s first map projection⁶³— however, it is hard for many scholars to say whether the maps included in such manuscripts were actually drawn up by Ptolemy, or by those who read his work.⁶⁴ Nevertheless, however, the maps included in Ptolemy’s *Geography* today (Fig. 5) do still line up with the map-making process he described, with ‘south’ at the bottom and ‘north’ at the top. Ptolemy, a man who lived and worked in Roman Egypt, someone whom about a century prior would’ve been called an Egyptian, had a perception of geography that is aligned not with Ancient Egyptian culture, but rather with the culture of the Romans.

The effect of Roman rule on Egyptian cartography therefore becomes evident; While Ancient Egyptian maps predating the Roman conquest have ‘north’ at the bottom and ‘south’ at the top, showing evidence of a ‘flipped’ perception of geography, maps produced from a Roman

⁶² Berggren and Jones, “Maps 1-8,” 94

⁶³ Berggren and Jones, “Introduction,” 45.

⁶⁴ Berggren and Jones, “Introduction,” 46.

Egypt have an orientation that places 'north' at the top and 'south' at the bottom, reflecting a Roman understanding of geography, seen in Roman maps. Given that the Ancient Egyptian map orientation is so closely tied with the importance of the Nile River in Ancient Egyptian culture, the rotation of map orientation that occurs following the Roman colonization of Egypt suggests a de-centralization of the Nile as the center and source of Egyptian life. With the Nile being so important, the fact that these changes occur additionally displays the heavy and lasting effects that Roman culture had in Rome's territories, as well as the Western World as a whole; After all, the entirety of the modern world still views earth in that same way. If Cleopatra and Mark Antony had won the Battle of Actium, perhaps the maps we use today would be different. Through this cartological examination, it becomes evident that maps can give us profound insight on the cultures they come from, and how those cultures can change in the wake of colonization and military conquest.

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